

AI 201 Persons Required: Research Doc

Research Goal

For this project, I wanted to better understand how my mom deals with stressful or overwhelming emails in her everyday life. Instead of designing for a broad audience, I focused on one real person and tried to understand what actually causes frustration, hesitation, and avoidance when she checks her inbox.

The goal wasn't just to "make email easier." It was to understand what makes certain messages emotionally exhausting and figure out what feeling supported could realistically look like for her.

Participant Background

My mom regularly receives emails related to appointments, scheduling, bills, school information, and other important tasks. A lot of the stress comes from not immediately understanding what the email is asking her to do, especially when the language feels formal, long, or overwhelming.

During the research process, I focused on:

- how she currently reads emails
- where confusion starts happening
- what causes her to delay responding
- what tools or workarounds she already uses
- what kind of support would actually feel useful to her

Research Methods

Interview

I had a casual conversation with my mom while she walked me through how she normally handles emails. Instead of asking scripted questions the entire time, I let the conversation flow naturally so I could understand her habits and frustrations more honestly.

Observation

I observed her opening and reading real emails on her laptop and phone while taking notes on moments where she paused, reread sections, switched tabs, or verbally reacted to something confusing.

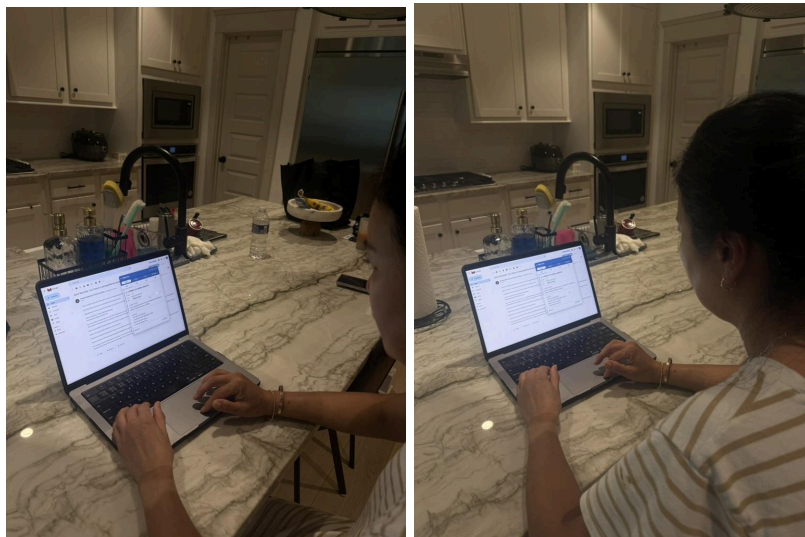
Follow-Up Questions

As she interacted with emails, I asked follow-up questions to better understand what she was thinking in those moments and why certain emails felt stressful.

Questions Asked

- **“What part of this email feels confusing?”**: “I don’t know what they actually want me to do. There’s too much extra wording and I feel like I’m missing something important.”
- **“What usually makes you decide to respond later instead of now?”**: “If I don’t understand it right away, I get tired thinking about it and tell myself I’ll do it later... but then I forget.”
- **“How do you normally remember to come back to emails like this?”**: “Honestly, I usually don’t. I either leave the tab open or mark it unread and hope I remember later.”
- **“What kinds of emails stress you out the most?”**: “Anything official. Appointments, school emails, bills, forms... especially if it sounds serious.”
- **“What would make this feel easier or less overwhelming?”**: “If someone could just break it down simply and tell me what actually matters.”
- **“Do you usually know what action you’re supposed to take right away?”**: “Not always. Sometimes I can tell it’s important, but I don’t know what they expect from me.”
- **“What makes an email feel urgent to you?”**: “Usually the tone. Even if it’s not actually urgent, if it sounds formal I assume I did something wrong or forgot something.”

Environment Notes



General Observations

- She usually has multiple tabs open at once while checking email
- Important emails often stay unread for long periods if they feel stressful
- She switches between email, Google Translate, calendar, and notes frequently
- Long paragraphs immediately make her slow down or avoid responding
- She tends to miss action items if they’re buried inside large blocks of text

Interview Quotes (Translated to English)

“Sometimes I read the same email over and over and still don’t really know what they want.”

“If it looks stressful, I leave it and tell myself I’ll come back later.”

“I get nervous responding because I don’t want to say the wrong thing.”

“I wish someone could just explain the important part to me.”

“A lot of times I ask you to read it first before I answer.”

“Some emails feel bigger or scarier than they actually are.”

Behavioral Notes

Avoidance: When emails looked long or formal, she often opened them briefly, skimmed the beginning, then closed them without taking action.

Re-reading: She reread the same sentences multiple times trying to figure out:

- what was important
- whether something needed action
- how urgent it actually was

Existing Workarounds

Some of the ways she currently manages this include:

- sending screenshots to family members
- using Google Translate
- marking emails unread as reminders
- leaving tabs open so she doesn’t forget
- writing reminders separately after reading emails

Emotional Reactions

Emails related to scheduling, payments, or official communication created the most visible stress and hesitation.

Main Pain Points

Pain Point	What I Observed
Hard to identify the important part	Frequently asked “What are they actually asking me to do?”
Overwhelmed by long/formal emails	Delayed opening or responding
Trouble keeping track of follow-ups	Relied on memory or handwritten reminders
Constantly switching between apps	Moved between email, calendar, notes, and Translate
Fear of making mistakes	Hesitated before replying or taking action

Key Insights

One of the biggest things I realized was that the issue wasn’t just comprehension. A lot of the stress came from uncertainty and emotional pressure.

She didn’t just need help reading emails; she needed reassurance, clarity, and a better sense of what actually mattered.

Another important insight was that support needed to exist directly inside her current workflow. If the tool lived somewhere separate, it would probably never become part of her normal routine.

Design Direction

After the research phase, the project started evolving into a lightweight plugin experience that could:

- simplify emails into clearer actions
- reduce emotional overwhelm
- highlight what actually needs attention
- help track reminders and follow-ups
- make the experience feel supportive rather than robotic

I chose a plugin format because the support needed to happen directly inside the email experience instead of requiring her to open a separate app.

Early Testing Notes

[PLACEHOLDER — insert prototype testing photos]

[PLACEHOLDER — insert screenshots of walkthrough]

Initial Reactions

- She immediately understood the simplified action sections
- She responded positively to calmer, more conversational language
- The reminder feature felt intuitive without explanation
- She wanted a clearer place to revisit saved reminders later
- She asked for additional guidance options when she still felt unsure about what to do next

Reflection

Doing research with a real person instead of designing for a hypothetical user completely changed how I approached the project. Watching someone hesitate, reread messages, and avoid stressful emails made the problem feel much more human and specific.

A lot of the final design decisions came directly from these observations, especially around emotional clarity, reminders, simplified actions, and creating a calmer experience overall.